

- Samudragupta also advanced through the forest tract of Madhya Pradesh to the coast of Orissa and then moved upto Kanchi, the capital of Pallavas.
- Some **coins** of the Samudragupta represent him as playing on the Veena. He also performed Asvamedha sacrifice.
- He was a devotee of Vishnu though a follower of the Brahmanical religion, he was tolerant of other faiths he granted permission to the Buddhist king of Ceylon, Meghavarman, to build a monastery at Bodh Gaya.

Chandragupta II (AD 380-412) (Chandragupta Vikramaditya)

- Samudra Gupta was succeeded by Chandra Gupta II around AD 375. However, some historians put **Ramagupta** between Samudra Gupta and Chandra Gupta II.
- In the play **Devichandraguptam** of Visakhadatta, Ramagupta is the elder brother of Chandra Gupta II. It was during the rule of **Ramagupta** that Shakas attacked Gupta Empire. Finding his position precarious, Ramagupta agreed to surrender Queen Dhruvadevi to a Shaka ruler.
- Chandra Gupta II objected to it and saved the honour of the family by killing the Shaka chief and rescuing Dhruvadevi. He later on married her. However, the Gupta records do not refer to Ramagupta.
- **Political marriages** occupied a prominent place in the foreign policy of the Guptas. Chandra Gupta II followed the same policy when he conciliated the Naga chieftains of the upper and central provinces by accepting the hand of the princess **Kubernaga** and allied himself with the powerful family of the Vakatakas of the Deccan by marrying his daughter Prabhavati with Rudrasena II.
- He issued silver coins (first Gupta ruler to issue silver coins) and adopted the title *Vikramaditya* and *Sakari* in memory of his victory.
- The Mehrauli iron pillar inscription near Qutub Minar enumerates the exploits of a king called **Chandra**.
- During his reign the Chinese pilgrim **Fa-Hein** (399-414) visited India.

NAVRATNAS IN CHANDRAGUPTA II'S COURT

Chandragupta II is credited with maintaining in his court 9 Luminaries or great scholars *viz.*, Kalidas, Amarsimha, Dhanvantri, Varahamihira, Vararuchi (Vartika-a comment on Ashtadhyayi), Ghatakarna, Kshapranak, Velabhatt and Shanku.

Kumaragupta I

Kumaragupta adopted the title of *Mahendraditya*. Founded Nalanda University (a renowned university of ancient India). Kalidas (The Shakespeare of India) flourished in the reign of both Chandragupta II and Kumargupta I. Kumaragupta was the worshipper of Lord Kartikeya (son of Lord Shiva, his vehicle is peacock).

Skandagupta (Fall of Gupta Empire)

He faced Hunas (a fierce nomads of Central Asia) effectively. The weak successors of Skandagupta could not check the growing Huna power. Feudatories rose in Bihar, Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, Vallabhi etc.

Administration

- Kings were called Parameshwara/Maharajadhiraja/Parambhattaraka. They issued the largest number of gold coins in Ancient India, which were called Dinars.
- The most important officer in the Gupta Empire was Kumaramatyas and they were appointed by the king in home province and they were mostly paid in cash. The Guptas has system of provincial and local administration empire was divided into bhukti and each bhukti was under charge of uparika. Bhukti was divided into district (vishyas) and it was placed under vishyapati. Village headman was very important during Gupta period.
- Lands were gifted to brahmanas by the Gupta kings and such grants were known as *Agraharas*.

Social Development

The castes were further divided into sub-castes. The practice of untouchability intensified (especially hatred for *Chandalas*). Fa-hien mentions that the Chandalas lived outside the village and were distanced by the upper class. Varna-Shankar became highlighted during this era.

Religion

The Bhagwad Gita was written and Buddhism declined during this period. Vishnu temple at *Deogarh* (near Jhansi), a small temple near *Sanchi* and a brick temple at *Bhitargaon* (near Kanpur) belong to the Gupta architecture.

Gupta Art and Crafts

- In art, architecture, sculpture, painting and terracotta figurines, the Gupta period witnessed unprecedented activities and development all over India. That is why, the period is also referred to as the **Golden Age of Ancient India**.
- The brick temples of the Gupta period include those of Bhitargaon in Kanpur, Bhitari in Ghazipur and Deogarh in Jhansi. The Buddhist University at Nalanda was set-up in the 5th century.

- The rock-cut architecture of the period is represented by the two conventional types - the Chaityas and the Vihara. They are mostly found at **Ajanta, Ellora, Bagh** and **Udaigiri caves** of Orissa.
- Gupta age marks the beginning of the main style of temples architecture in India namely the Nagara style and Dravida style. The finest example of temple architecture is the Dasavatara temple at Deogarh. It is also an example of early stone temple with a Shikara. It has a square grabhagriha with exquisitely carved doorway. Other examples of temple architecture are Parvati temple at Nachna Kuthara, Shiva temple at Koh, Cave temple at Udaigiri etc.

Famous Temples of the Gupta Age

Temple	Location
Vishnu Temple	Tigawa (Jabalpur)
Shiva Temple	Bhumara (Nagaud)
Parvati Temple	Nachna Kuthara
Dasavtar Temple	Deogarh (Jhansi)
Shiva Temple	Koh (Nagaud)
Bhitargaon Temple	Bhitargaon
Lakshman Temple	Kanpur (Brick made)
Lakshman Temple	Sirpur (Raipur)
Mukund Darra Temple	Kota
Jarasangh's Sitting	Rajagriha (Bihar)

Literature

Kalidas, the great Sanskrit dramatist, belonged to this period. His books are *Abhigyanashakuntalam*, *Bhagwad Gita*, *Ritusamhara*, *Meghadutam*, *Kumarsambhavam*, *Malvikagnimitram*, *Raghuvarsha*, *Vikramovarshiyam* etc.

Other Literary Works

Author	Book
Sudraka	Mrichchakatikam
Bharavi	Kiratarjuniya
Dandin	Dasa Kumar Charita and Kavyadarshan
Bhasa	Svapnavasavadattam, Charudatta
Vishakhadatta	Mudrarakashya Devichandraguptam

Science and Technology

- **Aryabhatt** the great Mathematician wrote the *Aryabhattiya* and the *Suryasiddhanta*. In the *Aryabhattiya*, he described the place value of the first nine numbers and the use of zero. He also calculated the value of π and invented Algebra. In the *Suryasiddhanta*, he proved that the Earth revolves around the Sun and rotates on its axis.
- In this way, he discovered the cause of the solar and lunar eclipses and the methods for calculating the timings of their occurrence. He also said that the heavenly bodies, like the Moon, were spherical.

- Lilavati of Bhaskara is written as standard text of mathematics.
- **Varahamihira** wrote the *Panchasidhantika* and the *Brihatsamhita*. He said that the Moon moves around the Earth and the Earth, together with the Moon, move round the Sun.
- **Brahmagupta** was a great Mathematician. He wrote the *Brahma-sphutic Siddhanta* in which he hinted at the 'Law of Gravitation.'
- University of Nalanda was set-up during the rule of Kumaragupta I, who become king in AD 415. This University of Nalanda is called Oxford of Mahayan Buddhism.
- Palakapya wrote the *Hastyagarveda*, a treatise on the disease of elephants. Kamandaka's Nitasara was written on the political morality.
- Court language was Sanskrit. Dhanvantri was a physician famous for Ayurveda knowledge.

POST GUPTAS

With the decline of the imperial Guptas at the end of 5th or the beginning of 6th century, Magadha and its capital Pataliputra, lost their importance. After the fall of the Guptas, five major centres of power and their centres emerged in North India.

The Age of Smaller Kingdoms

The disintegration of the Gupta empire gradually paved the way for the growth of many smaller kingdoms. The Maukharis started gaining political power towards the end of 5th century and hold over modern Uttar Pradesh and parts of Magadha. From the middle of 6th century till about AD 675 the kings who ruled Magadha were known as **Later Guptas**.

VARDHAN DYNASTY

Founder of Vardhan dynasty was Pushyabhuti Vardhan.

Harshavardhana (AD 606-647)

- Harshavardhana was the younger son of Prabhakaravardhana. Hiuen Tsang gave account of his reign, in his book, Si-Yu-Ki. Bana's Harshacharita, inscriptions, coins and Harsha's own writings i.e., Ratnavali, Priyadarshika and Nagananda, are other authentic sources of Harsha's era.
- Shashanka, the ruler of Gauda killed Grahavarman (Maukhari ruler) in alliance with Devagupta and imprisoned his wife Rajyasri (Harsha's sister). Later Rajyavardhana killed Devagupta, but he was assassinated by Shashanka in AD 606.
- The news of the death of Rajyavardhan reached his younger brother Harshavardhana, who now coronated himself in AD 606 and proceeded to avenge his brother's death and release his sister. From this year started the Harsha era.

Later Southern Indian Kingdoms

The Vakatakas

- Beginning of the 7th century, the Chalukyas of Badami, the Vakatakas and the Ikshvakus emerged as the three major states in Deccan. While in South India after the fall of Satavahanas, the Pallavas established a powerful kingdom.
- The kingdom was founded by Vindhyasakti, basically Brahmins. Most important king was Pravarsena-I who performed Ashwamedha Yajnas.
- Chandragupta II married his daughter Prabhavati to a Vakataka king Rudrasena-II and with his support succeeded in conquering Gujarat.
- It is said that the magnificent caves of Ajanta, Vihara caves and Chaitya caves belong to the Vakataka age.

The Chalukyas of Badami

- The Chalukyas grew powerful in Deccan in the middle of the AD 6th century. The dynasty had two branches viz. *Vatapi* (Badami) and *Kalyani*.
- **Pulakesin-I** was the founder of the Chalukya dynasty, but the most important ruler of the dynasty was Pulakesin-II who ruled from AD 610-642. He sent an ambassador to the Persian king Khusro II. The greatest achievement of Pulakesin II was that, he inflicted a defeat on Harshavardhana.

The Pallavas (Kanchi)

Simha Vishnu was founder of Pallavas dynasty. They set up their capital at Kanchi (identical with modern Kanchipuram). Pallava temples were usually free-standing. But one example of temple cut out of large rocks are the seven ratha temple (seven pagodas) at Mahabalipuram.

The Gangas

First and famous king of Gangas of Odisha was Ananta Varman (1076-1147) who established his power over the whole territory between the Ganga and the Godavari. He built the famous temple of Lord Jagannath at Puri. Kesari who used to rule Odisha before Gangas, built the famous Lingaraja temple at Bhubhaneswar.

The Cholas

- Founder of Cholas was **Vijayalaya** with Capital-Tanjore. Cholas were feudal of Pallavas. Important king was Rajaraj I. He built Brihadeshwar temple at Tanjore devoted to Shiva. This temple is also known as Rajarajeshwar Temple.
- His son Rajendra I annexed the whole of Sri Lanka. In the Pala king Mahipala, he took title of Gangaikonda after that. The empire was divided into 6 *mandalas* or province administered by Governors. Mandalams were further divided into Valanadus, Valanadus into Nadus and Nadus into Taniyars.

- The Gopuram style of art developed under Cholas. Local self-government was practiced during the reign of Cholas (concept of *Panchayati Raj* has been borrowed from it).

The Rashtrakutas

- The Rashtrakutas rose up against the Chalukyas under Dantidurga. Dantidurga founded this dynasty in AD 753 and made Manyakheta his capital.
- King Krishna-I further expanded the kingdom, but is best remembered in history as the builder of the rock-cut Kailash temple at Ellora.
- Rashtrakuta king Amoghavarsha I (814-880 AD) is compared to Vikramaditya in giving patronage to men of letters. He wrote the first Kannada poetry *Kaviraj marg* and *Prashnottar Mallika*.
- The King Krishna-III set-up a pillar of victory and a temple at Rameshvaram.

Bhakti Movement

During AD 7th century, Bhakti Movement started in South India. Two prominent saints came to fore

- (i) **Alvars** and (ii) **Nayanars**.
 - Alvars** These saints were worshipper of Vishnu. They venerated vaishnavism and regard vishnu as supreme. Collection of their hymns are called Divya Prabandha.
 - Nayanars** These saints were bhakti saints who worshipped the Hindu god Shiva. Women's participation was prominent in Nayanar. Both above bhakti movement started in present day Tamil Nadu.

Northern Indian Kingdoms (AD 750-1200)

The powerful kingdom arose between AD 750-1000. The Rashtrakutas were ruling Northern Deccan, the Pratiharas in Avanti and parts of Southern Rajasthan and the Palas in Bengal. All three were engaged in a continual tripartite struggle.

The Rajputs

- Rajputs came into prominence in 9th and 10th centuries.
- There is also a body of opinion claiming that some of them were foreign immigrants assimilated into Hindu fold over the centuries. Lastly there were the *Agnikulas*, the fire family. *They were as follow*
 - The Pratiharas or Parihars, not the same as the main Pratiharas but with whom they had connections.
 - The Chahamanas or (Chauhans)
 - The Chalukayas (or Solankis)
 - The Paramaras (or Pawars)

The Pratiharas (or Gurjara Pratihara)

- The foundation of one branch of Pratiharas was laid down by Harichandra, a Brahman near modern Jodhpur in the middle of the AD 6th century. **Bhoj** was the greatest ruler of this vast empire from Kannauj. He was also known as Adivaraha and Mihira.
- **Mahendrapala** is believed to have started his reign about 893. His teacher was Rajashekhara a celebrated poet, dramatist and critic author. Rajashekhara has the literary work like *Bal-Bharata*, *Bal Ramayan*, *Bhuvanosh*, *Harvilas*, *Karpuramanjari*, *Kavya Mimansa*, *Prapanch Pandav*, *Vidhsaal* etc.

The Chandellas

- The Chandellas became rulers in Southern Bundelkhand under Nannuka early in the 9th century.
- They had their capital at Kharjuravahaka (modern Khajuraho).
- They were a patron of learning and fine arts and built Kandariya Mahadeva temple at Khajuraho in AD 1000.

Chauhan

- Ruled over Shakambri (modern Sambhar–Rajasthan). Founder of Chauhan was Semharaja. Important king was Prithviraj Chauhan.
- First Battle of Tarain, 1191 Prithviraj Chauhan defeated Mohammad Ghori. Second Battle of Tarain, 1192 Mohammad Ghori defeated Prithviraj Chauhan.
- His court Poet was Chandbardai who composed Prithviraj Raso.

Gahadavals

They ruled over Kannauj. Important king was Jai Chand, he was defeated by Mohammad Ghori in 1194 in Battle of Chandawar.

The Chalukayas (Anhilwara)

- The Chalukayas or Solankis were rulers of Gujarat and Kathiawar for about three and a half centuries.
- Important ruler—Pulakesin II, Aihole inscription is associated with him, composed by his court poet Ravikirti.

The Paramaras

- The dynasty was founded by Upendra or Krishnaraja. The main branch of the Paramaras comprised descendants of the Rashtrakutas who ruled Malwa.

- Bhoja (1010-1055) is the best king of the Paramara rulers, also called as Kaviraj. He wrote the *Samaraganasutradhar* (a rare work on architecture) and the *Ayurvedasaravasva* (work on medicine).

Kingdoms in Bengal

The Palas of Bengal

- In the middle of the AD 8th century, the Pala dynasty came into power. Its founder was **Gopal** (AD 750) who was elected to the throne as he had proved his valour and capability as a leader.
- He was a Buddhist. He was succeeded by Dharmapala (AD 770-810) who won Kannauj.
- Dharmapala was succeeded by Devapala who won Orissa and Assam and was followed by Mahipala I. Mahipala was attacked and defeated by Rajendra Chola.
- Suleiman (an Arab merchant) visited them and was impressed. The Palas were patrons of Buddhism. Dharmapala founded the University of Vikramashila and revived Nalanda University.

The Senas

- After the Palas, the Senas established an empire in Bengal. The earliest member of the Sena dynasty was Samanta Sena.
- The greatest ruler of this dynasty was his grandson Vijayasena. Vijayasena was a devotee of Shiva. The muslim ruler Muhammad Bakhtyar Khilji attacked its capital Nadia and captured it.

Kingdoms in Kashmir

Following were the two important dynasties of Kashmir

Karkota Dynasty

The Karkota dynasty was founded by Durlabh Vardhan in 7th century. Lalitaditya Muktapid was the most important ruler of this dynasty. He constructed the Martand temple in Kashmir.

Lohar Dynasty

Sangramraj was the founder of Lohar dynasty. Kalhan was the court poet of Harsha, Lohara king. He wrote '*Rajtarangiri*' which contains the history of Kashmir.

> PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Read the following statement(s) with reference to the 6th century to 4th century BC.

1. The Mahajanapadas bear the names of the dominant Kshatriya lineage in most cases.
2. People in the 6th century BC did not know the use of iron.
3. By the 6th century BC a class of free peasants and merchants had emerged.
4. Private property in the form of animals, land and its produce had emerged by the 6th century BC.

Which of the statement(s) given above is/are correct?

- (a) Only 2 (b) 3 and 4
(c) 1, 2 and 4 (d) Only 4

2. Consider the following statements with regard to the Vedic texts.

1. Brahmanas deal with metaphysical problems.
2. Upanishad deal with methods of performing Vedic rituals.
3. Atharva Veda documents folk tradition.
4. Rig Veda carries linguistic similarities with the Avesta.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 and 3
(c) 3 and 4 (d) All of these

3. In the context of later Vedic age, read the following statement(s) and select those that may not be correct?

1. It cannot be said that the Vedic society shifted to East.
2. The Vedic society used iron technology mostly for weapons of war.
3. In agriculture only labour intensive technology was used.
4. People married outside their 'gotra'.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) 2 and 3 (b) Only 1
(c) Only 3 (d) Only 2

4. The following statement(s) provide interesting information on the rulers/dynasty of the ancient period.

1. Surya Varman II built the temple of Angkor Vat.
2. Apsad inscription throws light on later Guptas.
3. Hathigumpha inscription provides information on Kharavela.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) Only 1 (b) Only 2
(c) Only 3 (d) All of these

5. With regards to the early ancient Indian monuments and sculpture and their patrons, identify the correct pairs.

1. Amaravati : Satavahana
2. Cave shrines at Barabar hills : Ashoka
3. Kailash temple at Ellora : Rashtrakutas
4. Stupa at Shahji ki dheri near Peshawar : Kanishka

Codes

- (a) Only 1 (b) 1 and 2
(c) 3 and 4 (d) All of these

6. Regarding the early Vedic age, which of the following statements is correct?

- (a) The purohita or priest had no special place in the society
- (b) The 'Sabha' and 'Samiti' had no power in the selection of the Raja
- (c) Religion was not based on magico-ritual formulae
- (d) Gods were worshipped for the spiritual upliftment of the people

7. The Atharvaveda informs us about

1. the folk traditions of later Vedic period.
2. the elite traditions of later Vedic society.
3. the socio-religious conditions of the common people of Vedic society.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) Only 1 (b) 1 and 2
(c) Only 3 (d) 1 and 3

8. Match the following

List I (Harappan Sites)	List II (States)
A. Kalibangan	1. Haryana
B. Mohenjodaro	2. Rajasthan
C. Rangpur	3. Gujarat
D. Banawali	4. Sindh

Codes

- | | |
|-------------|-------------|
| A B C D | A B C D |
| (a) 2 4 3 1 | (b) 2 4 1 3 |
| (c) 3 4 2 1 | (d) 4 2 1 3 |

9. The early Buddhism incorporated pre-Buddhist elements, as is best demonstrated

- (a) in the worship of Buddha as icons
- (b) by the presence of large standing Yaksas and Yaksis
- (c) in the elaborate narrative scenes from the life of Buddha and from the Jatakas which reveal a strong ethical bias
- (d) in the incorporation of non-Buddhist deities and mythical concepts

10. The available information on the later Vedic age comes from different sources, including excavations, these have yielded archaeological evidence of different types at different places. Examine the following statement(s).

1. Iron axe at Noh.
2. Iron ploughshare at Jakhera.
3. Bones of cattle at Hastinapur and Atranjikhara with indications that these were used as a source of food.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) Only 1 (b) 1 and 2
(c) All of these (d) None of these

11. The Sun temple of Konark was built by Narasimhadeva I. To which dynasty did he belong to?

- (a) Somavamsi dynasty
- (b) Imperial Ganga dynasty
- (c) Suryavansi Gajapati dynasty
- (d) Bhoi dynasty

12. In the context of later Vedic period, what may not be correct?

- (a) Mixed farming which included cultivation and herding were the main subsistence activity
- (b) The importance of both Sabha and Samiti declined
- (c) Public and private sacrifices became very important
- (d) The important Later Vedic and Early Vedic Gods were different